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Author(s): Antonio Attisani and Jane House

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FRANCISCAN PERFORMANCE

A Theatre Lost and Found Again

Antonio Attisani
Translated by Jane House

EDITORS' NOTE: This essay is part of an ongoing PAJ series on "Art, Spirituality, and Religion" in which we plan to explore artworks and art practices circulating around this theme. The digital performance text, The Birth of the Christ Child, also appearing in this issue, is another approach to the subject, as is Karen Wilkin's essay on Pat Lipsky's new work. The series was initiated in PAJ 72 (2002) with publication of "Art as Spiritual Practice," a panel discussion featuring Meredith Monk, Alison Knowles, Erik Ehn, Linda Montano, Eleanor Heartney, and moderated by Bonnie Marranca, held at the SoHo gallery, Location One, in November 2001.

Trasumanar significar per verba non si poria . . .
(Passing beyond the human cannot be worded . . .)
—Dante, *Paradiso*, I, 70–71, translated by Allen Mandelbaum

If Francis of Assisi (1181–1226) had been considered as the initiator of modern theatre and not just as an eccentric saint, Western theatre would never have been the same. He would have started a completely different performing tradition. What I wish to outline here is not the story of that "if," but simply the Franciscan idea of theatre, or, rather, of performance. Franciscan theatricality does not consist of the illustration of an ideological statement (a concept or a text, that is, a discourse), nor can it be reduced to the simplicity of the *exempla*. In other words, it has nothing to do with representation, the foundation of Western post-Renaissance theatre. His theatricality consists of an incredible variety of *poetic actions* with the purpose of creating a communal experience of transformation. His theatricality is essentially ecstatic, as actors and spectators have an intimate comprehension of a religious event, or experience a state of peaceful pleasure. However, one has to acknowledge that the transformation is obtained through the activation of the senses and the creation of an aesthetic structure, that is, the creation of form. Another important issue to point out is that the participants in this theatre do not experience or conceptualize the event to the same degree but, rather, each has his or her own unique experience, taking part in the event as one "character" among others.

One of the purposes of this essay is to suggest that although Francis's conception of "theatre" was neglected through the passage of time, it nevertheless remained fertile ground for Western theatre and reappeared with some force in the twentieth-century avant-garde, which fought, as we know, against recitation and representation. Thus, I am led to consider Franciscan performance as fundamental to Western culture, although it is still largely unknown and undervalued as such, and to contemplate a Francis who is far removed from the popular view of him as patron saint of pan-ecological protest movements.

Since Western civilization based its construction of modernity and the *société disciplinaire* (Michel Foucault) on the conspicuous duality of the *text* and its *representation*, the Franciscan *Weltanschauung* was beyond comprehension. And even if Francesco di Bernardone, as he was also known, *had* described himself and his brethren as "actors" rather than "jongleurs of God" (*joculatores Domini*),¹ it would not have altered the fact of his censure and his subsequent canonization by the Roman Catholic church—or the fact that his *Cantico delle creature* (*Canticle of Creatures*) is now considered one of the precursors of vernacular literature.

Nor is it likely that this revised description would have influenced the work of scholars. In our own time, Ioan P. Couliano in his *Spiritual Journeys*, a brilliant study of ecstatic methods and their shamanistic roots throughout the world, never mentioned Francis because he did not leave behind any texts that addressed such topics.² While Erich Auerbach did include him in his tract on realism in Western literature, he limited his comments to Francis's scanty writings.³ And Ivan Illich⁴ wrote on "lay alphabetization" and "religious alphabetization," medieval Europe and modernity, the birth of the publishing industry, and of reading, without taking into consideration the Franciscan contribution.

Francis was not concerned with the written word; he conceived of life, his own as well as that of the good Christian and *in primis* that of the brethren, as a "revolutionary performance," in other words, as an action that changes the lives of the participants in a manner that re-actualizes the behavior of Jesus Christ and his idea of community. There were a few scholars who recognized the primary place of performance in his life. For instance, Auerbach stated clearly that, "everything he did was a scene. And his scenes were of such power that he carried away with him all who saw them or only heard of them."⁵ However, most scholars have ignored the originality of the theatrical elements in these "scenes." They emphasize, rather, that Francis attempted to *represent* Jesus Christ, that is, duplicate the images of his life, rather than emphasizing that he wanted to realize here and now the same principles, which is not the same thing. From the thirteenth century onwards, artworks were no longer created by anonymous artists, and authors become more and more important. For Francis, performance was a way of being that transformed reality; whereas the new authored form of performance became the "acting as," the representation-illustration of some texts, or ideas—a fictional mode requiring its own specialists and professionals.

Auerbach writes: “The core of his being and the impact of his life are centered upon the will to a radical and practical imitation of Christ” in contrast to the “predominantly mystico-contemplative form” prevalent at the time.⁶ The failure of most scholarship to recognize Francis’s true legacy can be explained, at least in part, by the view that theatre is something apart from history, having its own narrative. When considered at all, Francis’s work is only seen as evidence of a theatricality that came to its maturity in the Renaissance theatre. One of the few exceptions is the scholar Chiara Frugoni who, in commendably taking up the theme of Francis’s censure in orthodox ecclesiastical works, describes how—beginning in his own day—angry censors attempted to undermine his teachings, how he escaped them, and how his work survived as “non-text.” She affirms the central role of performance behavior in Franciscan work and explains how the most significant aspects of this theatrical form are incompatible with the values and behavioral models of the Church and of judicial power.⁷

It would be useful, at this point, to describe some scenes which demonstrate the rich typology of Franciscan performances and to note their underlying similarities:

(1) One Easter, upon discovering that the brothers were preparing to eat from a table laden with white napkins and glasses rather than from seated positions on the floor, Francis pretended to be a pilgrim. After humbly asking for some food, he sat on the floor alone and put his cup on the ashes, thus demonstrating the proper way for a Friar Minor to eat.⁸ In this way, he overcame the apparent impotence of words to affirm the humbleness of the table and showed, by making them believe him to be someone else before they recognized him, how the humble should behave. His objective was not only to set an example but also to lend to the image of proper behavior the power of allegory and thus make something immutably understood. The purpose of the action and the energy expended on it seem typical of a simple initiation rite, where the comprehension of a principle is physically transmitted.

(2) On another occasion, when he was exhausted by the *quartan ague* (*febbre quartana*) and suspected he had been given special treatment, he called together the people of Assisi. After preaching to them, he had himself dragged naked through the crowd and charged himself before them with having eaten meat.⁹ While this scene had shock value, it also produced an “alienation” effect in two areas—first with regard to the wealth of a Church to which the Friar Minors wished to belong but which they criticized for behavior that was at odds with their evangelical teachings, and second, with regard to Francis’s own reputation for saintliness. Noteworthy is the symbolic importance of the spatial sequence during the entire event: first, the elevated podium, an area designated for declamatory speech, where Francis preached; then the crypt, the deepest place, situated beneath the altar, where Francis revealed his nakedness and donned the noose of the condemned man; and finally, the way out to the horizontal level of the crowd, which is at one and the same time both a disorderly place and a place where genuine feelings of understanding and compassion can be evoked. Thus, the stages of the journey were transformed into as

many symbolic moments, and presented *not* in the usual form of intellectual exegesis, but as a concrete theatrical allegory.

(3) Another example shows how Francis transcended the ideological dimension of the sermon. After yielding to the pleadings of several nuns that he address them, he realized that his audience of women might be distracted by seeing the Father and the Man and that were he to give a sermon in the conventional way its essential meaning might be lost in dead words. So he adopted a solution that was quite different from any used up to that time: he traced a circle of ashes on the floor and stood still and silent at its center for so long a time that the entire hushed assembly was brought to tears. The silence was followed by a psalm, presented as an intense, moving chant.¹⁰ In this example, Francis is the creator of a voice and figure, conceived as empty receptacle, which draw in and hold the breath of God; thus, the event instills fresh life in a service that was at risk of losing its power in repetitive ceremony. The conditioned mind is tricked and befuddled by a sight which, rather than filling the spectators' minds and accosting their senses, empties them so they can have a transcendent experience.

(4) A very special performance was that of the construction of the first crib. According to accounts by Tommaso da Celano and Bonventura da Bagnoregio,¹¹ under Francis's instructions, a community was actively involved in the creation of a drama that would help them understand what the night of the birth of Jesus was like. People were asked to reconstruct the crib physically and then perform the events so that everyone, and especially the simple folk, could "see it with the eyes of the body" (with their senses), as Francis said, and participate in the epiphanic encounter between the mundane and the divine. At the end of this performance-play in which everyone was an actor—and hence, in which there was no audience—Francis gave instructions to leave the crib empty, so as to avoid the danger of mistaking the fiction for reality. According to him, one could achieve the capacity to "see" the Genuine with the eyes of the soul (mentally or intellectually), which occurred after his chanting and preaching.

In this last example, we encounter two aspects of theatrical performance: first, as an art form which alters the actor's state of consciousness, making him or her see (the transcendental experience); and second, as a teaching tool that makes a lesson manifest (and thus makes it lasting). The latter aspect was often characteristic of Franciscan performance. Francis is a creator of allegories that contain symbols and metaphors which have autonomous values of their own, the allegory being not a "literal lesson" but essentially a synchronic figurative composition with a logical order that each spectator must interpret for himself or herself.¹²

Beginning in the sixteenth century, theatre as a way of teaching was adapted—and given sophisticated ideological backing—for didactic drama, first in a Jesuit compass, and later by theatres of pre-eminently ideological mold, above all, but not only, by the twentieth-century agit-prop theatre of the left and the right. However,

while didactic drama serves to introduce models of behavior, it has a dry and intellectual feel, whereas the holy Franciscan event is physical and contagious, being in a sense similar to the theatre invoked by Antonin Artaud.

Francis loved to sing and used all kinds of instruments as accompaniment, thus imitating jongleurs and troubadours. Sometimes he even played a game of pretend when the real instrument was not available. Juan Antonio Merino reminds us that “sometimes he picked up some wood from the ground and, while he held it over his left arm, with his right he took up a bow bent by a string and passed it over the wood, accompanying himself with suitable movements, pretending that it was a viol and singing in French the praises of the Lord.”¹³ This evocation of Francis as “jongleur, troubadour, and knight” specifically indicates his performance models and draws one’s attention to the universal dimension of Franciscan language. We know he actually turned towards France to confront the Cathar heresy, and towards the Arab world where it is probable that he shared information on dances and ecstatic techniques with the fierce enemies of the Crusaders.

This cosmopolitanism reverberates in the terminology with which he surprises a Chapter of pundits gathered together to demand that the Rule assigned to the Friars Minor be inspired by those of Saints Benedict, Augustine, and Bernard. On that occasion, in order to stress the difference between his movement and the others, Francis defined himself once more as “*novellus pazzus in mundo*”: “The Lord told me that he wanted to create in me a new kind of fool for the world, and the Lord did not want to endow me with any other kind of wisdom.”¹⁴ This eccentric way of expressing himself to his interlocutors showed that he was part, even if he was unaware of it himself, of a specific tradition that is traceable from Japan through the whole of Europe, by way of China, India, Tibet, and the Arab world. It was a heterodox monastic tradition that in some measure assumes the form of institutional “fraternities,” in which the dimension of play and the values of enthusiasm and happiness—or of *divine madness*, or *mania* in the Platonic and Socratic sense—hold sway. While true (clinical) madness can be the cause and effect of suffering, *divine madness*, issuing from a habit of compassion, does not preclude immediate gratification for the compassionate one. The power and fascination of ecstatic techniques lie in their very ability to induce enjoyment or, in other words, physical and mental pleasure.¹⁵

This is not the place for a catalogue of examples or for an exhaustive discussion of them or of Francis. The episodes cited above help define certain issues that are very important for all those involved in theatre. Above all, it should be clear that Francis adopted an artistic procedure. His events are creations on the edge of the verbal which develop into “trans-rational” communications, such as talking with animals. The hagiographers tell us that Francis often communicated with animals (birds, wolves, etc.) by uttering sounds, not words; they understood each other through Affects, not Concepts. In this sense, Francis can be considered an excellent example of Deleuze’s “real writer.” His artistry has a non-institutional feel about it and no

regular system (specifically, no formal procedures, no specialized meeting places, a devotion to experimentation and study that does not develop into “professionalism” or become a closed entropic system). The sense of surprise, estrangement, and, above all, focus come to pass only through the freedom of continuous invention and variation. Meyerhold, who suggested that each *mise-en-scène* should create a completely new and different kind of theatre, would have admired Francis, that ancient “mystic anarchist” who never repeated a performance solution.

Theatre can be represented by the design of a triangle: two angles are the actor and the space in which he acts, and the third is the lone spectator. There are many triangles, as many as there are spectators, and they are always in movement, for quantitative (physical) as well as qualitative (psychological) reasons. We can use the term “triangle” to indicate a triangular relationship, which is open because it is three-way.¹⁶ At least, that is Michel Serres’s idea, the spectator being the “instructed third” angle, the active recipient of the teaching. According to Serres, Arlecchino’s costume symbolizes a sort of “cultural body,” which retains traces of Arlecchino’s encounters. In this image, Serres is not advocating a general syncretism, but is referring to the typical Franciscan wandering, performing and “being performed” by the people encountered and the places visited. This explains why Franciscan philosophy (can we define it differently?), though marginalized for centuries, reappears with extraordinary suggestiveness at the end of the modern era, when artistic specialization and professionalism seem not to respond to the deeper expectations of art.

Francis’s work and his use of theatre as a means both of changing the actor’s state of consciousness and of teaching raise a number of questions: Is the theatrical triangle used to “instruct” and, if so, how does it differ from the mystical-contemplative moment? More precisely: What does the theatre mean to its creators? In what sense is it both a transcendence (a sort of profane prayer) and an instruction (a sort of initiation) at the same time? And for the spiritual researcher, is theatre an art that does not produce any object? How much is the performance outer directed and how much inner directed? Finally, how does the triangle work in contemplation? What is the stage setting for the mystical? How do the techniques of mystical travel compare with those to instruct or make manifest? Some answers may lie in the triangular arrangement which characterizes the theatrical encounter (Francis who makes himself spoken to by God and seen by the spectators) and that of meditation (Francis who speaks to God and from there can relate only the essence of the messages he receives).

But the deeper (or ultimate) question one needs to ask regards theatrical action. To approach it, we can look at the research of two well-known figures of twentieth-century theatre: Konstantin Stanislavski and Jerzy Grotowski. Stanislavski abandoned any hope of summarizing in book form his immense knowledge of theatre not only because he did not believe a written source capable of transferring such knowledge, but also because his later ideas were quite different from his earlier ones. Consequently, during his final years when he was engaged in serious research

through the rehearsal process, he tried desperately to work out and transmit the “method of physical actions” to a small group of gifted actors. The book by Vasily O. Toporkov, who witnessed these sessions, is the only written record of this work, and although clear, the book has limitations.¹⁷

In the contemporary theatre, by 1968 Grotowski had already abandoned any theatrical activity that was conceived as the production of spectacle and was devoting himself to work that began exactly where Stanislavski left off. In his case too, very few documents record this work apart from the memoirs of participants. Among these is the book by Thomas Richards, his disciple and actual heir.¹⁸ What Stanislavski and Grotowski have in common is precisely surpassing the idea of theatre as representation and conceiving of theatre instead as action and event with no spectators, only participants or witnesses. Generally speaking, actors are transformed through their execution of physical actions, while participants experience transformation through first-hand involvement with the events themselves.

Without denying the importance of Grotowski’s later work on “art as a vehicle,” which can be appreciated only by a closed circle of invited witnesses, we should bear in mind that his research of truth led to an art without form. “Art without a form” is how the Dalai Lama defined the work on themselves of meditative monks, while what we call “art,” both secular or sacred, is something made manifest through forms. Grotowski’s work is something which is outside of theatre, if theatre is a place where the public comes to be confronted by forms. In my experience, the most significant contemporary example of theatre surpassing theatre is François Tanguy’s Théâtre du Radeau. (If we had more time we might also consider the recent co-production of Thomas Richards and Mario Biagini that seemed to be conceived on similar coordinates.)¹⁹ In the case of Théâtre du Radeau, all the elements of the theatrical environment are involved in physical actions. The actors do not represent or recite, even when they use the words of Dante and Shakespeare, they sculpt space and time. They do not create beautiful images or fix important concepts, they create a dynamic allegorical situation.²⁰

Returning full circle to Francis of Assisi, his example helps us realize, if we keep an historical perspective in mind, not only that “avant-garde” practices can be ancient in origin, but also that avant-garde movements are ethically and even religiously oriented, that they work toward the creation of temporary communities which share experiences, creating a sort of democracy of the spirit, and that they struggle against “easy” or habitual actions (affects and percepts, according to Deleuze). Taking an historical perspective also helps to demonstrate why and how certain cultural options that have been “defeated” or subsumed by the course of history can continue to operate in different times and contexts, sometimes reappearing as a significant cultural option. And that is why the Franciscan non-representational theatre—like theatre of similar traditions—can be said to exist on the horizon as an option for creators of theatre.

The reconsideration of Francis's work helps to focus many themes as well as understand how contemporaneous in nature are the issues. What we find is that physical actions are a core idea in both Francis's work and in the theatrical realm. And we are faced with the not less important questions of allegory and the "grotesque." At first it may seem strange that the creation of allegory is the aim of physical actions, but when we consider that physical actions are traditionally a form of poetry and that they reach beyond the literary meanings of words, the question can be viewed in another light. Allegory is more than an historical style produced by the Baroque. It is a creative impulse: it eludes (or, escapes) ideological precepts and the judicial system and proposes art both as a space of freedom and as an "ethos of transcendency;" that is, it derives from the need to be free from being judged. At the same time the grotesque style—the perpetual surprise created by alternating heterogeneous elements—of the Franciscan theatrical composition pushes both the performer and the spectator to consider (human) nature as something to be perpetually deconstructed and reconstructed.

The conception of the body that is implicit in Francis's work is also a very compelling idea: the body as both prison and playground, the body which changes its state until it achieves what Antonin Artaud would later refer to as the state of the "body without organs," thus overcoming a stage in life which would otherwise come upon one suddenly as terrible punishment. In this sense, the Franciscan experience has something to say about the questions posed by Artaud, and later conceptualized by Deleuze, regarding art as production (not representation) of affects and the making of a "disorganized" body. It also contributes with some authority to the current debate on changes brought about by the computer era, in particular with regard to the multiple interactions between levels of reality and to notions of what the body is and how it functions. These issues are important and must certainly be addressed, provided that they avoid ideological oversimplification and the pseudo debate about the simple Franciscan "message."²¹

The purpose of Franciscan performance, which is based on the rejection of representation and of its degraded rituals, is not to provide information, simulate reality, postulate ideas, or even set an example, but to present some fundamental mind-body problems with inescapable clarity; in other words to present a *theatrical truth*. The objective is to induce a reaction in the audience, to have them experience something together. To make this happen, one must have a talent for theatrical (poetic and figurative) composition and be adequately skilled in the theatrical arts; that is to say, one should consider constructing a work from experimentation and improvisation. Scholars who show no interest in theatre are not of much help in this regard, as in the case of Auerbach, who interprets Francis from the perspective of realism.

Francis rejects the inert language of the Church and brings symbols to life in a powerful way, without using text or aspiring to do so. By this means, he evades the degenerative process of knowledge-power based on the written word and on censorship of the organic, a process destined to spread rapidly and one which, one

has to admit, has produced extraordinary innovations in the history of art. In fact, we can agree with Henry Thode, the great art historian of the nineteenth century, when he says that the Renaissance in art began with Giotto:²² from that moment sublimation was destined to replace the sublime, and the aesthetic (textual, literary), the ecstatic. Giotto's frescoes in the Scrovegni Chapel in Padua and in the basilica in Assisi are two founding monuments of Western art. However, they are also magnificent examples of this divergence between ecstatic and representational strategies.

It is now possible to comprehend why the Franciscan way of conceiving of the actor could not be acknowledged or accepted: it was part of a pattern (or a philosophical practice) that is "anti-historical" and has generally disappeared into an enigmatic haze. Still, something of Francis has undeniably survived and now operates in non-textual forms of theatrical life that are extraneous to the institution of theatre, though pertinent to its essence.

That essence is the actor. The ecstatic skills of the mystic create a theatre of the interior where one is author, director, actor, and spectator (the "divine" is nothing imaginable or explicable, one just arrives there). On the other hand, performance techniques or skills (production, representation, action, all focused outwards towards the spectators) create a catharsis of joy and grace, where the actor is ecstatically transported and the spectator undergoes initiation. The madness of the holy or ecstatic actor can manifest itself in various ways, depending on circumstance, and can appear as stupidity or even desperation, since the feelings of peace and pleasure and gratification do not dispel the torment of living, but only make one penetrate it so that it is no longer apparent. The techniques and skills of the mystic and the professional actor could be similar, except that the former *is formed* by and in ecstasy, while the second *takes form* (becomes visible, that is) in performance, in stage action. The heresy of Francis derives from his being outside the perspective of "text" and the "judicial system."²³ This system—based on the supremacy of the culture of the written word and of such specialized disciplinary places as tribunals, prisons, asylums, schools, etc.—spread very rapidly in his time, as the actions of the future St. Bonaventure demonstrate. Bonaventura, the spiritual leader of the Franciscans, the so-called Minors, for seventeen years, upheld the thesis that Francis was a figure "to admire but certainly not to imitate." Bonaventura was also a strong supporter of the judicial system and believed in the prime importance of the written text.²⁴

It is said that one aspect of the Franciscan revolution consists in not being "against," in not wearing oneself out in acts of rebellion, but in trying other forms of life. These forms can be called theatricality and actoricity, actor being to actoricity what theatre is to theatricality. Both pertain to the realm of the social. Thus conceived, the scenic arts undoubtedly have ancient shamanistic roots but do not depend on archetypes or on the inane symbolism of a worldly Church. Rather, they are part of an *experimentum fide*, an original process of improvisation and invention, experimentation and research, to seek what is natural and true. The work and artifice

necessary to this endeavor must not pollute this choice of a life; on the contrary, they must lead to greater simplicity and an adherence to what is by nature divine.

The Franciscan actor's work consists not in building something but in clearing the way (in a psychological sense). He does not express his personality but his individuality, something quite different.²⁵ The actor fights against the theatre, to abolish it, insofar as it represents a branch of the judicial system, thus serving the theatre and being served by it. In the process of abolishing the theatre, the actor consumes himself as he follows his own pathway towards silence. This stage, once reached, requires no exhibition, no performance, the actor is transformed into what Artaud called the "glorious body," and Grotowski the "saint." That is its own reward. There is no longer any need for theatre.

My purpose in this article has been very simple: to present a few fragments of reflection, of personal reflection, about Francis that might generate some dialogue in the intellectual community. Because—and this is what I want to emphasize—the study of Francis's biographies is as important to the actor or to the theatre scholar as the study of the Sacred Scriptures is to believers. These contradictory documents contain a conception of theatricality that could prove of special importance for outlining a theatre of the present and the future, at least on a *philophysical* level. One can speculate whether this is only a matter for believers. What for Francis is divinity, for non-believers can be, at the same time, an emptiness and a fullness, the placement of an action that goes beyond the limits of textuality and judgment, beyond the limited dialectic between the Ego and the Other.

When Dante writes about Francis in *Paradiso* that "Passing beyond the human cannot be worded . . ." he means that Francis's actions, or performances, are an authentic path towards, and struggle for, Paradise. Earlier, Dante had written to his sponsor Cangrande della Scala (Epi. XIII) that his own divine poem would be a "comedy," a sort of peasant chant and dance in which he aimed to create a language derived from actions rooted in real life and capable of moving beyond the human towards Paradise. Dante recognized that Francis had made (performed) "a divine comedy" before he wrote his own, and, surprisingly, compared Franciscan Umbria to the Ganges plain of India, both being places that gave birth to the sun.

NOTES

1. See Tommaso da Celano, *Vita seconda*, XC, 127, in *Fonti francescane*, Editio Minor, Assisi: Editrici Francescane, 1988, pp. 432–432, and *Leggenda perugina*, 43, *ibid.*, p. 792. The first text tells us about Francis's way of chanting, about his use of the "French" language and of troubadour techniques, and about how he imitated their gestures and the sound of the "viella," their typical five-stringed instrument. In this work, we are told that Francis "traboccava in giubilo" (was overwhelmed with jubilation), and for "jubilation" we must look to Augustine's definition: "non una pronuncia di parole, ma un certo suono di letizia senza parole, la voce dell'animo tradocante di letizia" (not the pronunciation of the words,

but a certain sound of joy without words, the voice of the soul springing with joy). The *Leggenda perugina* tells of Francis asking Friar Pacifico, in his former life a famous singer known as “the king of verses,” to teach the jongleurs’ techniques to the friars.

2. Ioan P. Couliano, *Out of This World*, Boston: Shambhala Publ., 1991.

3. Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis. The Representation of Reality in Western Literature*, translated from the German by Willard R. Trask, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1953.

4. Ivan Illich, *In the Vineyard of the Text: A Commentary to Hugh’s “Didascalicon,”* Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993.

5. Auerbach, *op. cit.*, p. 162. In reality Auerbach employs the term “representation” (German *Darstellung*), here translated as “scene.”

6. *Ibid.*

7. Of Chiara Frugoni see: *Francesco, un'altra storia*, Genova: Marietti, 1988; *L'invenzione delle stimmate*, Torino: Einaudi, 1993; and *Vita di un uomo: Francesco d'Assisi*, Torino: Einaudi, 1995. The first work examines the table dedicated to Francis which one can see in the Bardi Chapel at Santa Croce, Florence; the second work is a fuller study of Francis and the opposition to his teaching, and describes how the stigmata were thought to be an invention of the friars; the third is a pocket book that promotes all the author’s new theories.

8. The episode is described in Tommaso da Celano, *Vita seconda*, XXXI, 61, in *Fonti francescane*, *op. cit.*, pp. 378–379.

9. See *Leggenda perugina*, 39, in *Fonti francescane*, *op. cit.*, pp. 787–788.

10. See Tommaso da Celano, *Vita seconda*, CLVII, 207, in *Fonti francescane*, *op. cit.*, pp. 493–494.

11. Tommaso da Celano, *Vita prima*, XXX, 84, in *Fonti francescane*, *op. cit.*, pp. 267–270, and Bonaventura da Bagnoregio, *Leggenda maggiore*, X, 7, *ibid.*, pp. 605–606.

12. Cfr. Angus Fletcher, *Allegory: The Theory of a Symbolic Mode*, Ithaca, NY: Cornell Univ. Press, 1964.

13. Juan Antonio Merino, *Umanesimo francescano*, Assisi: Cittadella, 1984, pp. 297–298.

14. See *Leggenda perugina*, 114, in *Fonti francescane*, *op. cit.*, p. 860. On this theme there are many passages in the Franciscan Sources; on Francis as a fool see *Vita prima*, V; *Leggenda dei tre campagne*, VI, 17, and VII, 21; *Fioretti*, II; and on the friars as fools see *Leggenda dei tre campagne*, IX, 34–35; *Fioretti*, XX; Witness of Buoncompagno da Signa, in *Fonti Francescane*, *op. cit.*, p. 1001.

15. On the theme of action and pleasure one can see Thaddé Matura, *Il progetto evangelico di Francesco d'Assisi oggi*, Assisi: Cittadella, 1982. There would be a lot to say on the Franciscan practice of non-violence which, far from advocating passivity, encourages vigorous action; just as there would be a lot to say about the, as yet, misunderstood Franciscan call for a joyful outlook which springs from the saint’s childlike, poetic soul, but which has often been erroneously transformed into an accepted meaning suggesting menace and gloom. An example of this change is the “dance macabre,” a dance which early Franciscan missionaries probably brought to Europe, that celebrates man’s liberation from

his physical bonds; in the West it has been transformed into an iconographic segment of a harsh treatment of death.

16. See Michel Serres, *Il mantello di Arlecchino*, Venezia: Marsilio, 1992, and his idea of “instruction.”

17. Vasily Osipovich Toporkov, *Stanislavski in Rehearsal*, N.Y. and London: Routledge, 1979; Italian edition, *Stanislavskij alle prove—Gli ultimi anni*, ed. by Fausto Malcovati, Milano: Ubulibri, 1991.

18. Thomas Richards, *At Work with Grotowski on Physical Actions*, N.Y.: Routledge, 1995.

19. *One Breath Left*, with Ang Gey Pin (Singapore), Foo Jong Soon Julius (Singapore), Tan Pei Hwee (Singapore), Yap Sun Sun (Singapore), Mario Biagini (Italy), Marie De Clerck (Belgium), Souphière Amiar (Algeria), Juri Piroddi (Italy), Jörn Riegels Vimpel (Norway). A work created at the Workcenter of Jerzy Grotowski and Thomas Richards, as part of the project “The Bridge: Developing Theatre Arts,” *One Breath Left* was directed by Mario Biagini and Thomas Richards, Pontedera, 2001.

20. On the Théâtre du Radeau and its surpassing the so-called “theatre of images,” see Marie-Madeleine Mervant-Roux, *Le ré-imaginement du monde. L’art du Théâtre du Radeau*, in Béatrice Picon-Vallin, ed., *La scène et les images*, Paris: CNRS, 2001.

21. St. Francis is a popular subject in Italy today. Various books and theatrical productions have sprung up, including the important book by C. Frugoni, *op. cit.*; Dario Fo’s *Lu Santu jullàre Francesco*, in which Fo also acted—published as book and videocassette (Torino: Einaudi, 1999); and the kitsch musical *Ma va tutto bene* by Vincenzo Cerami (who won an Oscar for *Life is Beautiful*) which was presented in Assisi in a building (The Lyrick Theatre) constructed specifically for that purpose. Time after time, Francis has become an excellent ideological or economically profitable business. No theatre critic has pointed out how absurd it is to use Francis as a subject for tales, being that he was not for storytelling but for action. In *Ammonizioni*, VI, 3, in *Fonti francescane, op. cit.*, p. 81, he says: “The saints have acted; in our discourses and preaching we limit ourselves to exploiting their activity for the purpose of obtaining for ourselves honor and glory.”

22. Henry Thode, *Franz von Assisi und die Anfänge der Kunst der Renaissance in Italien*, Berlin 1885, 1904; It. ed., *Francesco d’Assisi e le origini dell’arte del Rinascimento in Italia*, Belosi, ed., Rome: Donzelli, 1993.

23. According to Gilles Deleuze, the judicial system philosophically defines Western culture from Plato onward and is responsible for the progress and limitations of the Right. See, *Essays Critical and Clinical*, Minn: University of Minnesota Press, 1997.

24. The bibliography of and on Bonaventura da Bagnoregio (1221–1274) is quite vast. General of the Franciscan order from 1257, Cardinal from 1273, Bonaventura is considered one of the major mystics of the Middle Ages. He follows principally in the footsteps of Saint Augustine and Ugo di San Vittore. Among his most famous works are *Itinerarium mentis in Deum* and, of course, *Legenda Maior*, the official biography of Francis. Besides ordering the total destruction of all copies of prior biographies of Francis and writing his own synthesis inspired by the idea that the saint was “to be admired but not imitated,” the life and works of Bonaventura are full of suggestions that he had in mind a grandiose religious project of a modern, intellectual kind.

25. Peter Brook talks of this when referring to the mask in *The Shifting Point: Theatre, Film, Opera 1946–1987*, New York: Theatre Communications Group, Inc., 1994.

ANTONIO ATTISANI teaches the history of theatre at University Ca' Foscari, Venice. Among his recent publications are *Oltre la scena occidentale* and two volumes on Tibetan theatre. His essay on Tibetan opera appeared in *PAJ* 63. Jane House co-edited, with Antonio Attisani, *20th-Century Italian Drama: An Anthology, The First Fifty Years* and has translated works by Petrolini, Rosso Di San Secondo, and Santanelli.